At one point, The Family had acquired as many as twenty-eight children. There were little altars to Anne Hamilton-Byrne all over the house and each child was given a personal photograph of her, as if she was Mao. The cult was obsessed with sex and with cleanliness. Anne herself had, it seems, an insane kind of vanity. She hated ugly or fat people and had recourse to cosmetic surgery.

Leif Meynell was part of that cult. And everything he did relating to us was informed by his association with The Family. At one point, running from him, we were living in the Adelaide Hills and we had to move again, this time to Perth in Western Australia. We went to Freemantle, which is now a cool suburb, but then it was mainly an industrial dockyard area. We had a neighbour who knew all about our situation, and, one day, she came back from the milk bar to tell us that Leif Meynell had been in the street. We had to flee. We ended up that time at a house in the Patch, outside Melbourne, on a long narrow plot that slumped down towards a creek at the bottom of the hill. Once I found a dead sheep in this creek, stinking and bloated. I walked backwards and forwards across the creek, using its back as a kind of bridge. It was a time, perhaps, when all sorts of extraordinary things could come to seem pretty normal. It was a cold winter, the puddles freezing over, and my footprints in the mud would be overlain by a layer of ice. They appeared like the steps of a man on the moon preserved under glass. I had to chop wood and stoke a fire every morning to heat the water that passed through coils in the chimney. My main recreation then was bees that I kept outside the house. Every morning I attended to them and quietly watched as they went about their business.

Bees have a way of dealing with predators. They keep moving and they always die away from the hive. I'm sure the isolation I mentioned before, the sense you get in some parts of Australia that civilisation is elsewhere, caused these cults to thrive. In that farming community, they had a strange attitude towards animals, and there was a satanic vibe thereabouts. I even remember a satanic-ritual shop run by a figure called Kerry Calkin. In those parts, it was all fairly pedestrian, but frightening nonetheless. The atmosphere was like *Lord of the Flies*, and our lives at the time were filled with a combination of paranoia and guilt.

It was becoming so tiring. Just moving all the time. Being on the run. We got some intelligence that Leif was drawing close; they told us he was back near us in the hills outside Melbourne. My brother and I showed a lot of